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From the Economy of Empathy to the Economy of Suffering: Corporate Humanitarian Communication and the Accountability Paradox

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Abstract

Humanitarian communication has historically operated through a relationship between spectators who witness distant suffering and sufferers who are witnessed. Corporate technological interventions have structurally replaced that relationship. The humanitarian register no longer addresses publics as witnesses but secures partnerships with UN agencies and INGOs, producing authority through institutional transactions rather than empathic engagement. The article terms this the shift from an economy of empathy to an economy of suffering. Through analysis of thirteen corporate interventions in the platform, financial, connectivity, data/AI, and energy sectors between 2012 and 2025, the article advances two arguments. The first establishes that the conditions generating humanitarian authority are structurally identical to those preventing accountability, making the deficit constitutive rather than correctable. The second develops a typology of three forms of foreclosure (discursive, architectural, ontological erasure) specifying how affected communities are positioned within corporate humanitarian systems and how the available forms of contestation differ across them.

Keywords: techno-humanitarianism, technocolonialism, constitutive communication, accountability, humanitarian communication, platform governance, witnessing

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In March 2022, Airbnb activated its global host network to provide free temporary accommodation to Ukrainian refugees (Airbnb.org, 2022). Within weeks, the platform had housed over 100,000 displaced people, outpacing several established humanitarian organisations. The company's communications positioned Airbnb as enabling hosts to respond at a speed and scale that traditional humanitarian architecture could not match. Yet the refugees housed through the platform were addressed not as rights-bearing subjects under international protection law but as service users, governed by the platform's terms and conditions, dependent on the willingness of individual hosts in a marketplace. The platform performed a humanitarian function without producing the humanitarian subject that function presupposes.

A year later, the CEO of Mastercard addressed the United Nations Security Council. The address described digital cash programmes as "a fast, transparent, secure and more effective way to deliver life-saving assistance at the last mile" (Miebach, 2023, para. 23). It framed the company's humanitarian role as "putting the whole of our businesses into service" (Miebach, 2023, para. 14). Through the Mastercard Aid Network, the company deployed its payment infrastructure across refugee settlements in Jordan and Lebanon, among other settings, framing financial inclusion as dignity and consumer choice as empowerment. Yet World Bank research documented that communities enrolled in Mastercard-backed humanitarian payment systems had no mechanism to contest decisions made about their accounts, including the suspension of access to assistance (World Bank, 2020). Industry publications describing the same initiative presented the programme's commercial development function without ambiguity. The humanitarian register and the commercial logic

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did not converge accidentally. The register constituted the commercial operation as humanitarian.

These two cases occupy different sectors and operate through different technological infrastructures. They share, however, a communicative pattern in which a corporate actor acquired humanitarian authority through specific public communications while the communities governed by that authority gained no means of holding the corporation accountable. The question this article asks is how that communicative pattern operates, and what it produces for the communities subjected to it.

The empirical literature on humanitarian communication has developed along several productive lines, none of which examines how corporate actors themselves communicate. Research on communication production within humanitarian organisations has shown how professionals navigate ethical and instrumental pressures, with visual imagery becoming a site of conflict between fundraising departments and advocacy teams (Orgad, 2013; Wright, 2018). Audience research has identified how Western publics respond to mediated suffering across affective, ecstatic, politicised, and detached modes of engagement (Kyriakidou, 2015, pp. 219–220). Archival work has traced how contemporary digital humanitarian tools remediate earlier paper-based technologies of colonial population management, revealing a continuity of "technophilia" as an "imaginative framework" across centuries (Seuferling and Leurs, 2021, p. 670). Single-case studies have examined specific technologies in specific crisis settings, from blockchain in Jordanian refugee camps (Jutel, 2021) to refugee storytelling on TikTok (Marino, 2024). The closest precedent for treating corporate and institutional communicative material as primary data is a study of UNRWA's internal communications during US funding cuts (Fiddian-Qasmiyeh, 2019), but the institution examined is a UN agency, not a corporate actor. Across this body of work, the communicative material through which corporate technology becomes legible as

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humanitarian, including press releases, CEO addresses, partnership announcements, and corporate responsibility reports, has not been subjected to systematic analysis.

This article addresses that gap. It analyses thirteen corporate interventions across five technologically mediated modes (platform, financial, connectivity, data and AI, energy), drawing on a corpus of 134 documents collected between 2012 and 2025 and deposited at Harvard Dataverse. The article argues that the structure of humanitarian communication has undergone a transformation that the existing literature has documented at the theoretical level (Chouliaraki, 2013; Madianou, 2019, 2025; Nothias, 2025) but has not examined empirically through the communicative material itself. The structure of witnessing that connected publics to distant suffering, positioning them at "the difficult juncture between experience and discourse" (Peters, 2001, p. 710), has been replaced by a corporation-institution relationship in which suffering functions as the occasion for institutional partnership rather than as the object of empathic response. The article terms this the shift from an economy of empathy to an economy of suffering.

The article advances two arguments from this transformation. The first is the constitutive accountability paradox. The conditions that generate corporate humanitarian authority (speed and scale of deployment, bypass of institutional gatekeeping) are structurally identical to the conditions that prevent accountability. The deficit is not correctable, because restoring accountability would require reintroducing the processes whose absence is the source of the authority claim. The second argument is a typology of three forms of foreclosure through which governance positions are produced for affected communities and the available forms of contestation differ across them. Discursive foreclosure constitutes positions through language that can in principle be contested through counter-discourse. Architectural foreclosure embeds positions in platform infrastructure, contestable only through system exit, which in humanitarian settings means leaving the aid relationship.

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Ontological erasure, a concept conceptualised in this article, identifies the prior condition in which affected communities do not register within the system's moral field at all. Together, these arguments specify why accurate, sustained public testimony failed to alter any of the corporate arrangements examined in this study, and why the failure is structural rather than contingent.

Theoretical Framework

Techno-Humanitarianism as Constitutive Discourse

The concept of techno-humanitarianism, coined to describe technological solutionism applied to humanitarian governance (Morozov, 2012) and subsequently developed to examine the technologising of humanitarian space as a field of biopolitical control (Tazzioli, 2020), names a phenomenon that two existing frameworks have analysed from adjacent positions without specifying its communicative mechanism. The post-humanitarian framework traced a shift from solidarity-based engagement to a "self-oriented morality" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 3) in which the "subordination of the other-oriented aims" to "the self-oriented imperative of profitable performance" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 6) restructured the moral grammar of humanitarian communication. The technocolonialism thesis identified how the "convergence of digital developments with humanitarian structures and market forces" (Madianou, 2019, p. 1) produces systems in which the framing of intervention as "'technology for good' forecloses critical questions regarding the asymmetries" it produces (Madianou, 2025, pp. 16–17). Both contributions treat humanitarian discourse as one element within a broader configuration. The convergence thesis distributes explanatory weight across multiple logics (humanitarian, commercial, solutionist, securitarian), and this distribution implies that reform of any single logic might in principle reduce the accountability deficit.

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The postcolonial critique, however, suggests a stronger reading. The argument that "Western cultural/institutional representations of, and benevolence towards, the Third World can conceal a range of complicities" (Kapoor, 2008, p. 4) treats benevolence as a concealment mechanism, and the intellectual history of digital colonialism pushes this further, identifying that the system "relies on a discourse of 'benevolence' meant to tamper, if not obfuscate, the violence of this system" (Nothias, 2025, p. 388), where the verb "relies on" designates dependency rather than co-occurrence. Benevolence, on this reading, is not one feature of the colonial relationship but the mechanism through which the relationship is rendered acceptable. Techno-humanitarianism, accordingly, is not a descriptive category for the use of technology in humanitarian response but a constitutive discourse through which corporate technological governance over vulnerable communities is legitimated as care.

If these two accounts, convergence and precondition, are competing explanations of the same phenomenon, they should generate different expectations about the communicative material. Under a convergence reading, a corporate text announcing a technology deployment in a refugee settlement would contain separable registers operating in parallel. If humanitarian discourse functions as a precondition, the humanitarian and commercial registers should not be separable, because the humanitarian vocabulary is what secures the institutional partnerships that make the technology deployable. The concept of "infrastructural violence" that is "normalized and legitimated by the practices of digital consent and feedback mechanisms" (Madianou, 2025, pp. 25–26) approaches this second reading by treating legitimation as a mechanism rather than a by-product, but the convergence framework places that mechanism alongside other logics rather than recognising it as the condition that makes the others operate.

Capital Conversion and Constitutive Communication

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The precondition claim requires a mechanism. In the standard field-theoretic account, capital conversion between institutional domains is temporally extended, as actors entering a new field acquire its dominant capital form through sustained engagement and progressive accumulation (Bourdieu, 1986, p. 252; 1993). The humanitarian field has historically operated through precisely this temporality, with organisations accumulating mandate, proximity, and accountability relationships over decades. The constitutive communication tradition suggests a different temporality, since communication is "the primary, constitutive social process" (Craig, 1999, p. 126) through which institutional reality is produced, and authority is produced and reproduced through communicative acts that are ratified or contested by the audiences they address (Cooren, 2010). If institutional reality is communicatively constituted, then a single public communication, an announcement that frames a commercial payment system as humanitarian infrastructure, can produce institutional ratification without the temporally extended credentialling that field theory assumes.

The evidence from humanitarian communication research supports the constitutive reading, since in humanitarian visual communication "the most useful images are those that validate such intervention and invest the actions of NGOs with authority, whether or not such images depict actual situations with any accuracy or truth" (Manzo, 2008, p. 638). The brand functions as the institutional form through which this conversion is accomplished, since brands organise "the conditions under which meaning circulates and power is distributed" (Kornberger, 2010, p. 17), and the concept of the brand as an "institutional embodiment of the logic of a new form of informational capital" (Arvidsson, 2006, p. 1) identifies it as a mechanism for capital transformation rather than merely a vehicle for communication.

Business communication scholarship has recognised that corporations construct moral authority through strategic positioning, but has analysed this process through either intent-

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oriented studies evaluating whether corporate moral claims are sincere (Vredenburg et al., 2020; Mukherjee and Althuizen, 2020) or impact-oriented studies measuring material consequences (Bhagwat et al., 2020; Sibai et al., 2021). Both approaches presuppose that the communicative act represents a corporate position that exists prior to and independently of the communication. The constitutive tradition reframes this relationship, since an expressive account would predict that insincere humanitarian framing is less effective than sincere framing, whereas a constitutive account predicts that the institutional effects (partnership formation, regulatory deference, media ratification) operate regardless of corporate intent, because they are produced by the communicative act itself. The speed of capital conversion under crisis conditions is not incidental to the mechanism but constitutive of it, because the same temporal compression that enables the conversion is the temporal compression that prevents institutional oversight from engaging before the deployment is operational. The conditions that produce humanitarian authority and the conditions that prevent accountability are structurally identical.

Communicative Authority and Relational Address

The speed of capital conversion explains how corporate humanitarian authority is produced, but not what this authority does to the communicative relationship between the corporation and the publics who encounter it. The politics of pity establishes a communicative relationship between a spectator who observes suffering and a sufferer who is observed (Boltanski, 1999, pp. 3–19), and the concept of "proper distance" specifies what this relationship requires, namely "the more or less precise degree of proximity required in our mediated interrelationships if we are to create and sustain a sense of the other sufficient not just for reciprocity but for a duty of care, obligation and responsibility" (Silverstone, 2007, p. 47). When corporate actors enter humanitarian spaces, they do not solicit a response from the spectator but announce technological deployments as humanitarian accomplishments already

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achieved. The "theatrical arrangement" separating "safe spectators from vulnerable others" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 27) breaks down as a result, because the spectator is no longer positioned at "the difficult juncture between experience and discourse" (Peters, 2001, p. 710) but at a juncture between corporate performance and public ratification.

This repositioning eliminates the communicative conditions under which an accountability claim could be generated, since irony presupposes an appeal to be ironic about, and the "consumer-savvy bystander" equipped "with sophisticated analytical tools to assess and critique the style, function and effects of the appeal" (Seu, 2010, p. 452) has no object to assess when the communication presents a fait accompli rather than a solicitation. The technologies through which this fait accompli is communicated compound the problem, since they "disconnect as well as connect" and "the distance they create between interlocutors, between subjects, undermines the expectation of responsibility and reciprocity that action and communication in face-to-face settings conventionally require" (Silverstone, 2007, p. 23). The institutional conditions enabling this transformation are well documented, as public-private partnerships, impact investment frameworks, and the displacement of rights-based criteria by efficiency-based criteria progressively repositioned corporate actors as legitimate humanitarian participants (Barnett, 2011; Hopgood, 2013), while the humanitarian sector's orientation toward a practice that "deals with the world as it is" with "no ambition to remake the world" (Barnett, 2020, p. 12) privileged the capacities that technology corporations possess over those that traditional humanitarian actors accumulated over decades. This shift was already visible as aid agencies moved from being "sources of news to being co-producers of it" (Wright, 2018, p. 86) and as accountability became "directed primarily towards news organizations and audiences, rather than towards their supposed beneficiaries" (Wright, 2018, p. 87).

Subject Positions and Foreclosure

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The elimination of the spectator's accountability position raises the question of what positions are produced for affected communities. The framework of justificatory registers provides one specification, since the argument that legitimate social orders depend on a plurality of registers, each with its own internal logic (Boltanski and Thévenot, 2006), implies that accountability requires the availability of multiple registers through which a claim can be evaluated. Corporate techno-humanitarian communication narrows this plurality to a single admissible register, humanitarian concern, so that the only legitimate evaluative question becomes whether the technology alleviates suffering, while the questions that other registers would generate (whether it concentrates power, whether it creates dependencies) become inadmissible. Recognition, under these conditions, encourages "the reification of group identities and the displacement of redistribution" (Fraser, 2000, p. 109). Affected communities are recognised as beneficiaries and their dignity is invoked, but this recognition is allocated on terms that preclude demands for redistribution or political standing. The recognition is genuine, but its function is to affirm identity while leaving structural inequality intact.

The structure of witnessing deepens this problem, since witnessing involves a chain of mediated relay in which "the witness (speech-act) of the witness (person) was witnessed (by an audience)" (Peters, 2001, p. 709), and publics engage with mediated suffering across "affective, ecstatic, politicised and detached" modes shaped by "the combination of the sense of involvement" with "the sense of powerlessness that distance perpetuates" (Kyriakidou, 2015, pp. 217, 219–220). All four modes assume that the spectator is responding to the condition of the affected community. Corporate techno-humanitarian communication redirects the object of witnessing from the condition of the affected community to the technological capacity of the corporate actor. Recent work extending the witnessing framework demonstrates what happens when technological systems do the witnessing, since

For Review Only

sensor networks produce positions in which "uncertain bodies were swiftly fixed as 'military-aged males' and thus subject to potential elimination" (Richardson, 2024, p. 38). The witnessing apparatus constitutes the category through which the person is acted upon, so that classification and observation are the same act.

The subject positions produced through traditional humanitarian communication are discursive, so that a refugee positioned as a "beneficiary" occupies a position constituted through language that can in principle be contested through counter-discourse. Corporate techno-humanitarian intervention, by contrast, produces positions through a different mechanism. When the terms of the relationship are embedded in platform terms of service, algorithmic categorisation systems, or biometric registration requirements, the position is produced at the level of system design, and contesting it requires not counter-discourse but exit from the system, which in humanitarian settings means leaving the aid relationship entirely. A third form of foreclosure operates prior to both of these. The concept of ontological erasure, conceptualised in this article to complement the preceding two forms, identifies the condition in which subjects are not positioned within the system's moral field at all. The problem at this level is not misrepresentation but the failure to register as legible existences within the communicative order that the technology establishes. In humanitarian technology deployments, this condition applies to communities whose situation does not fit the platform's operational categories, whose suffering cannot be formatted into the system's grammar of care, or who are not enrolled in the registration system that mediates access to the technology.

[Insert Table 2 about here]

Methodology

Research Design and Case Selection

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The study adopts a qualitative multiple case study design (Yin, 2018; Stake, 1995) with discourse-analytic coding conducted through framework analysis (Ritchie and Spencer, 1994). The unit of analysis is the communicative process through which a corporate technological actor constitutes itself as a humanitarian authority and positions crisis-affected communities as subjects of that authority. Framework analysis is preferred over critical discourse analysis because the research question concerns how communicative acts constitute institutional relationships across multiple cases, not how ideological positions are reproduced within individual texts. The coding dimensions function as discourse-analytic categories specifying communicative mechanisms (capital conversion, register narrowing, witnessing redirection) rather than thematic codes applied to content. Framework analysis permits deductive coding from these theoretically prior categories while remaining open to inductive patterns, and suits the interpretive orientation of the research question because it builds analytical categories through structured engagement with the material rather than testing pre-specified variables (Eisenhardt, 1989).

Thirteen cases were selected across five technologically mediated modes, following replication logic within modes and maximum variation logic across them (Yin, 2018; Patton, 2002). The five modes (platform, financial, connectivity, data and AI, energy) function as a sampling framework, not a finding. In each mode, the technology itself is the medium through which the corporate actor communicates humanitarian authority and simultaneously encodes the governance position of affected communities. Within each mode, an anchor case and one or two secondary cases introduce variation in crisis type, organisational scale, and institutional partnership structure. Two structural contrast cases (Amazon logistics, Dyson ventilators) deploy material capacity without producing digitally encoded subject positions and are referenced for analytical contrast but excluded from the primary analysis.

[Insert Table 1 about here]

For Review Only

Corpus, Coding, and Analytical Focus

The corpus comprises 134 documents collected between 2012 and 2025 across the thirteen cases, deposited at Harvard Dataverse. For each case, three document classes were collected. Organisational communications (63 documents) include press releases, corporate responsibility reports, partnership announcements, and executive addresses. Media coverage (51 documents) includes news reporting, investigations, and editorial commentary from English-language outlets, treated as a record of public reception rather than factual verification. Civil society reports (20 documents) include advocacy publications, open letters, and legal filings from organisations contesting the corporate intervention. Collection continued until theoretical saturation was reached for each mode (Glaser and Strauss, 2017).

The coding procedure applies five discourse-analytic dimensions developed in the theoretical framework. Communicative capital conversion identifies lexical register shifts from commercial to humanitarian vocabulary, operational capacity framed as a humanitarian credential, and partnership announcements that ratify the humanitarian identity. The constitutive accountability paradox identifies textual features through which the conditions producing authority are structurally identical to those preventing accountability, including crisis rhetoric that suspends institutional process and speed of deployment presented as a credential. Register narrowing identifies whether the text admits evaluation through multiple justificatory registers or narrows the evaluative frame to humanitarian concern alone, and whether recognition operates in a containing mode (Fraser, 2000, p. 109). Witnessing redirection identifies whether the text positions the spectator to witness the condition of the affected community or the technological performance of the corporate actor. The three forms of foreclosure distinguish positions constituted through language (discursive), positions embedded in platform design (architectural), and the absence of communities from the system's moral field entirely (ontological erasure). The analysis proceeded in three stages.

For Review Only

The first pass applied these dimensions deductively to the full corpus. The second pass identified inductive patterns not anticipated by the framework, including the recurrence of temporal markers and the role of institutional occasion in authority accumulation. The third pass conducted cross-case comparison within and across modes.

Three cases receive close analytical treatment. The Airbnb case (platform mode, 13 documents) presents the clearest instance of communicative capital conversion, where a marketplace technology is reconstituted as emergency shelter infrastructure through a single public announcement. The Mastercard case (financial mode, 12 documents) contains the most extensive documentation of register narrowing, with humanitarian and commercial registers operating simultaneously across corporate addresses, trade coverage, and civil society contestation. The Palantir case (data and AI mode, 17 documents) presents the strongest evidence of architectural foreclosure and the most developed contestation record, with 65 civil society organisations contesting the WFP partnership. The remaining cases provide supporting evidence and cross-modal comparison.

For each case, organisational communications were read against their reception in media coverage and civil society reports (Lincoln and Guba, 1985), and where corporate framing and civil society counter-discourse directly contested the same claims, the contestation provided a triangulation check on the analytical interpretation. The study has limitations. The restriction to English-language sources privileges globally visible actors. The analysis examines corporate communicative production and its public reception but does not include reception data from crisis-affected communities. The energy mode contains a single case, limiting comparability within that mode.

Findings and Discussion

The introduction asked how the communicative operation through which corporate technology becomes humanitarian works, and what it produces for the communities subjected

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to it. The corpus evidence supports a direct answer. The operation works by replacing a humanitarian communication system organised around empathy between spectators and sufferers with one organised around institutional transactions between corporations and humanitarian organisations. Suffering is no longer represented in order to produce a response. It is presupposed as the condition under which commercial infrastructure gains access to institutional partnerships. What this produces for affected communities is a condition in which the accountability mechanisms available within the previous system, those of testimony and counter-argument, of public exposure and institutional advocacy, cannot reach the system that has replaced it.

Two Patterns

Across the anchor cases, the corpus evidence reveals two patterns. The first is the replacement of the spectator-sufferer relationship with a corporation-institution relationship. In every anchor case, the corporate texts address institutional partners and publics rather than the affected communities. The Airbnb Ukraine announcement (01a-OC-001) addressed hosts and publics. The Mastercard CEO addressed the UN Security Council about operational capacity (Miebach, 2023). The Palantir-WFP joint announcement presented data governance over 90 million beneficiaries as a "moral imperative" (04a-OC-001). The affected community is the occasion for the institutional transaction, not a party to it.

The humanitarian vocabulary in these texts simultaneously generates the authority claim and narrows the evaluative framework. The Airbnb vocabulary of domesticity ("home, not shelter") replaced a protection relationship with a market relationship (01a-OC-005; 01a-OC-006). The Mastercard phrase "financial inclusion" redescribed enrolment in proprietary payment infrastructure as a right. The "seeding the market while delivering humanitarian aid" framing, published openly by Mastercard staff in the Emergency Nutrition Network (02a-

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OC-002), shows that the humanitarian and commercial functions are not separate registers but a single activity.

[Insert Table 3 about here]

The second pattern is the constitutive accountability paradox. In every anchor case, the operational feature generating the authority claim is structurally identical to the feature preventing oversight. The speed of the Starlink deployment was the absence of consultation. The Airbnb deployment bypassed protection procedures, producing the service-user position (01a-OC-006). The Palantir partnership processed data at a scale requiring intelligence-grade infrastructure, and 65 civil society organisations contested it without producing any change to its terms (04a-CS-001; 04a-MC-005). The testimony against Palantir-WFP was sustained over years, accurate, and institutionally supported, including Amnesty International (04a-CS-003), Privacy International (04a-CS-002), and a UN Special Rapporteur (04a-MC-006). The partnership was extended. The testimony did not fail because it was inaccurate or insufficiently publicised. It failed because the system it contested is not constituted through communicative relationships that testimony can enter.

These two patterns raise two questions that the remainder of this section addresses. The first is what the replacement of the spectator-sufferer relationship means for how humanitarian communication produces authority, given that the critical literature has consistently assumed the spectator as a necessary participant. The second is what the failure of testimony despite its accuracy and institutional support means for how accountability operates when subject positions are encoded in platform architecture rather than produced through discourse.

The Disappearance of the Spectator

The corporate texts analysed in this study do not address the spectator as a witness of suffering. They present completed operational transactions, measured in stays booked (01a-

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OC-003), beneficiaries processed (04a-OC-004), and consumers reached (02a-OC-004), and position the spectator, if at all, to ratify an already-accomplished fact. The public is invited to see the corporation's operational reach, not the conditions of the communities it governs.

This is analytically distinct from the ironic spectatorship that the post-humanitarian framework diagnosed (Chouliaraki, 2013), because the ironic spectator still participated through consumption, still occupied a position within the moral grammar of the humanitarian relationship. The witnessing typology that audience research has produced, distinguishing affective, ecstatic, politicised, and detached modes of engagement with distant suffering (Kyriakidou, 2015, pp. 219–220), presupposes a communicative structure in which the spectator is being addressed as a witness to suffering and asked, however imperfectly, to respond. The finding from the corpus evidence is not that the spectator has adopted a fifth mode. The finding is that none of the four modes can be activated when the texts do not constitute the spectator as a witness at all.

The same structural absence is visible at the level of the communicative format. VR humanitarian films simulate proximity through gaze direction and spatial immersion, producing what one analysis termed "interpersonal affective textures" that cater to the viewer's emotional needs while obscuring geopolitical causes (Gruenewald and Witteborn, 2022). The VR format assumes that the spectator wants to feel something in relation to suffering and that the technological medium can produce that feeling more effectively. The corporate announcement does not make this assumption, because it operates independently of any audience response. The Mastercard CEO's Security Council address (Miebach, 2023), the Palantir-WFP impact page presenting 100 million beneficiaries per year (04a-OC-004), and the Airbnb impact update presenting 210,000 stays (01a-OC-003) all communicate within institutional channels in which the spectating public is neither addressed nor required.

For Review Only

This represents a qualitative threshold that the post-humanitarian trajectory anticipated but did not specify, because the trajectory from solidarity through irony to self-orientation (Chouliaraki, 2006, 2013) still assumed an audience-oriented communicative structure. Research on public responses to humanitarian communication identified a tension between audiences who desired relational, long-term engagement with beneficiaries and organisations that relied on an emergency model prioritising short-term emotional response (Seu and Orgad, 2017). That tension assumed that both parties were oriented toward the same communicative field, however imperfectly matched. The corporate texts dissolve this tension by eliminating the public as the relevant audience. Whether the public's desire is relational or transactional, it cannot affect a system that does not depend on public engagement for its institutional standing.

The distinction between seeing and testifying (Peters, 2001) clarifies the mechanism. In an economy of empathy, seeing distant suffering produced moral obligation because the witness entered a relationship with the sufferer. When the object of seeing is corporate performance, that relationship does not form, and the corporation's institutional authority continues regardless of whether the spectator confirms it, ignores it, or contests it.

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Register Inseparability and Capital Conversion

The Mastercard "seeding the market while delivering humanitarian aid" evidence (02a-OC-002) reveals a further dimension of this transformation. The Mastercard staff who published this framing described a single activity in which the humanitarian and commercial functions were inseparable.

This is analytically distinct from the ethical-instrumental tension documented in humanitarian practitioner research (Nolan and Mikami, 2012), where professionals navigated a split between value rationality and pragmatic necessity that they experienced as a discomfort precisely because the two registers were understood as distinct. In corporate

techno-humanitarian communication, there is no split to navigate, because the humanitarian vocabulary constitutes the commercial operation rather than competing with it.

The capital conversion this produces (Bourdieu, 1986, p. 252) operates through constitutive communicative acts (Craig, 1999, p. 126; Cooren, 2010, p. 42) that accumulate from the 2013 WFP e-card launch (02a-OC-005) through the 2016 White House summit (02a-OC-003) to the 2023 Security Council address, each sufficient to produce institutional ratification. The speed of this conversion matters analytically because it is the same speed that prevents accountability mechanisms from engaging before the deployment is operational.

The Airbnb evidence confirms that this structure predates any single crisis. A legal analysis published in 2019 documented humanitarian branding through West Bank settlement donations (01a-CS-002), and the Ukraine deployment scaled a vocabulary already in operation. Research on UNRWA showed how a specific funding crisis triggered a shift into neoliberal humanitarian logic within a UN agency (Fiddian-Qasmiyeh, 2019). The evidence analysed here extends that finding from a single institutional crisis to a permanent condition. The economy of suffering is not produced by crisis. Crisis is the condition it requires.

From Discursive to Architectural Foreclosure

The Palantir-WFP case makes the constitutive accountability paradox visible in its sharpest form because the testimony against the partnership was everything that accountability theory would require. Sixty-five civil society organisations identified an "accountability vacuum" (04a-CS-001). Amnesty International confirmed that "the same company providing WFP life-saving assistance was enabling documented abuses" through ICE (04a-CS-003). A UN Special Rapporteur called the arrangement "a monstrosity" (04a-MC-006). Internal employees contested the ICE contracts (04a-MC-007). The testimony was sustained over years, and the partnership was extended (04a-MC-005). The WFP CIO compared WFP to "Netflix and Uber" (04a-MC-001). Even the contestation sources

For Review Only

evaluated data-processing arrangements rather than the conditions of the communities whose data was being processed (04a-MC-003).

The question this evidence poses is not why the testimony was insufficient but why accurate, institutionally supported testimony could not alter the system it contested. The answer lies in the difference between discursive and architectural foreclosure. Research on humanitarian organisations found that efforts to help beneficiaries "tell their own stories" were constrained by organisational imperatives that directed accountability "primarily towards news organizations and audiences, rather than towards their supposed beneficiaries" (Wright, 2018, p. 87). The constraints that research identified were discursive. Beneficiary voice was shaped and redirected by organisational logics, but the possibility of voice was preserved because the communicative relationship between the organisation and the beneficiary was visible, institutionally defined, and in principle contestable.

In the Palantir and Airbnb cases, the question of beneficiary voice has been structurally precluded rather than merely constrained, because the communicative relationship is between corporation and institution, and no position within it accommodates beneficiary testimony. The Palantir biometric system addresses the affected community as a data subject whose categories cannot be inspected or challenged without leaving the aid relationship entirely. The Airbnb eligibility page addresses the displaced person as a platform user whose terms of service constitute the relationship itself (01a-OC-006).

The difference between the Mastercard and Palantir cases sharpens this distinction. The ICRC's naming of the Mastercard operation as "surveillance humanitarianism" (02a-CS-001) was analytically powerful because the accountability deficit was discursive, encoded in the language used to describe the operation, and counter-discourse could rename it. In the Palantir case, counter-discourse named the problem with equal accuracy and the partnership expanded, because the positions produced for affected communities were encoded in the

For Review Only

system's architecture rather than in the language used to describe it. Archival research has demonstrated that paper-based humanitarian management systems, however coercive, constituted a visible bureaucratic relationship in which a governed subject presenting a ration card engaged a human official who could be addressed and challenged (Seuferling and Leurs, 2021). The digital systems analysed in this study do not constitute a visible relationship at all. What changes between discursive and architectural foreclosure is not the degree of coercion but the availability of a communicative position from which the governed subject can contest the categories applied to them.

The Limits of Testimony

The simultaneous operation of Palantir in humanitarian and enforcement domains makes this structural disconnection between testimony and system fully visible. Amnesty International documented that Palantir systems enabled ICE operations during the same period in which the company governed food assistance data for 90 million WFP beneficiaries (04a-CS-003; 04a-OC-001). A DropSite News investigation reported Palantir AI "already playing a major role in tracking Gaza aid deliveries" (04a-MC-006). The humanitarian vocabulary insulated the partnership not by concealing the enforcement connection, which was public, but by making the humanitarian and enforcement deployments assessable only within their own separate vocabularies.

The persistence of the arrangement despite sustained testimony suggests that testimony operates within the economy of empathy, whereas the system it contests operates within the economy of suffering. Research on blockchain humanitarian projects identified how such initiatives serve the broader crypto-economy through humanitarian deployments (Jutel, 2021). The Mastercard and Palantir evidence supports this finding but specifies the communicative mechanism. The humanitarian vocabulary does not function as image

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management but rather as the condition of institutional access, without which the commercial function could not operate in humanitarian settings.

The Starlink case demonstrates why this accountability failure follows from the communicative architecture itself. The speed that made the deployment faster than any institutional alternative was the absence of the consultation, partnership, and oversight processes through which accountability is produced. The Airbnb deployment similarly bypassed protection procedures (01a-OC-006). The Mastercard Aid Network operated through commercial infrastructure not subject to humanitarian governance, producing the card-blocking documented by the World Bank (02a-MC-004). In each case, the feature generating the authority claim is the feature preventing oversight. The accountability deficit is not a gap that improved regulation could fill but a structural consequence of the communicative architecture itself. Restoring accountability would require reinserting the spectator-sufferer relationship into a system that has structurally bypassed it, which is the condition this article terms the constitutive accountability paradox.

[Insert Figure 1 about here]

The two arguments developed in this section identify a structural transformation in humanitarian communication that the existing critical vocabulary does not fully capture. The post-humanitarian account assumed that the spectator-sufferer relationship remained the organising structure of humanitarian communication, even as the spectator's moral orientation shifted from solidarity to self-interest (Chouliaraki, 2013). The technocolonial account assumed the same structure while demonstrating that multiple logics, humanitarian and commercial among them, converge within it (Madianou, 2019). The corpus evidence suggests that this shared assumption no longer holds. The spectator-sufferer relationship has been replaced by a corporation-institution relationship in which suffering functions as the condition of institutional access rather than as the object of empathic response. The

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accountability mechanisms built on empathy, including testimony, cannot reach a system constituted through institutional transactions and encoded in platform architecture. The economy of empathy assumed that humanitarian legitimacy depended on the quality of the relationship between the humanitarian actor and the public. The economy of suffering shows that legitimacy is produced through institutional access, and that the public's response, whether empathic, ironic, or indifferent, is structurally irrelevant to the operation of the system.

Conclusion

The post-humanitarian account assumed that the spectator's moral orientation was shifting, from solidarity through irony to self-interest, but that the spectator-sufferer relationship remained the organising structure of humanitarian communication. This article has argued that the transformation is more fundamental. The spectator-sufferer relationship has been replaced by a corporation-institution relationship in which the humanitarian register secures partnerships with UN agencies and INGOs rather than addressing publics as witnesses of suffering. The analysis terms this the shift from an economy of empathy to an economy of suffering.

The analysis has limitations that remain open for empirical investigation. The corpus is restricted to English-language documents and to corporate actors headquartered in the Global North, which may exclude communicative dynamics operating in other languages or through Southern-led technological initiatives. The five-mode typology does not claim exhaustiveness, and corporate humanitarian interventions that do not involve technological mediation, such as logistics or manufacturing conversion, may produce different communicative structures. The study examines the communicative material itself and does not include reception data from affected communities, whose experiences of these subject positions remain empirically unexamined.

For Review Only

If the accountability deficit documented here is constitutive rather than incidental, regulatory reform within the existing communicative architecture cannot resolve it, because the architecture itself is the mechanism producing the deficit. Restoring accountability would require structural changes to how corporate actors enter humanitarian fields, changes that would reintroduce the institutional gatekeeping, temporal extension, and public engagement that the speed of corporate deployment has bypassed. Whether such changes are politically feasible is a political question rather than an analytical one. What the analysis establishes is that the question of accountability in corporate technological humanitarian governance is not a question of better oversight applied to an otherwise functional system. It is a question about who constitutes the communicative relationship through which governance over crisis-affected communities is exercised, and whether those communities occupy any position from which they can contest that governance on their own terms.

For Review Only

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Table 1

Case Selection Matrix by Mode, Organisation, Initiative, Crisis Type, and Period (2012 to 2025)

Mode	Role	Organisation	Initiative	Crisis type	Period
Platform	Anchor	Airbnb / Airbnb.org	Emergency housing programme	Displacement / conflict	2012–2025
	Secondary	GoFundMe	Disaster and refugee crowdfunding	Multiple emergencies	2015–2025
	Secondary	Lyft	LyftUp disaster response	Natural disaster	2017–2025
Financial	Anchor	Mastercard	Aid Network	Displacement / aid delivery	2015–present
	Secondary	Visa	Humanitarian payments infrastructure	Displacement / conflict	2015–present
	Secondary	Western Union	Refugee remittance programme	Displacement	2016–present
Connectivity	Anchor	SpaceX	Starlink Ukraine deployment	Armed conflict	2022–2025
	Secondary	Cisco	Refugee connectivity programme	Displacement	2015–present
	Secondary	Google	Project Shield	Human rights / civil society	2013–present
Data and AI	Anchor	Palantir	UNHCR and WFP data analytics	Displacement	2016–present
	Secondary	Google	Crisis Response / FireSat	Multiple emergencies	2017–present
	Secondary	Microsoft	AI for Humanitarian Action	Multiple emergencies	2018–present
Energy	Anchor	Tesla	Powerwall emergency microgrids	Natural disaster	2017–present

Note. Each mode classifies a communicative act, not an organisation type. The Lyft case carries reduced analytical weight because of limited documentation. The energy mode contains a single anchor case.

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Table 2

Analytical Concepts

Concept	Definition	Source
Economy of empathy	Humanitarian authority produced through spectator engagement with suffering	This article
Economy of suffering	Humanitarian authority produced through institutional transactions; spectator structurally irrelevant	This article
Communicative capital conversion	Market capital converted into humanitarian authority through a single communicative act	Bourdieu (1986); Craig (1999); Cooren (2010)
Constitutive accountability paradox	Conditions producing authority structurally identical to conditions preventing accountability	This article
Register narrowing	Evaluative plurality reduced to a single admissible register (humanitarian concern)	Boltanski and Thévenot (2006)
Witnessing redirection	Object of witnessing shifts from community's condition to corporation's performance	Peters (2001); Kyriakidou (2015)
Discursive foreclosure	Positions constituted through language; contestable through counter-discourse	This article
Architectural foreclosure	Positions embedded in platform design; contestable only through system exit	This article
Ontological erasure	Communities absent from the system's moral field entirely	This article

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Table 3

Corpus Evidence Across Anchor Cases

Case	Authority claim	Institutional endorsement	Counter-evidence	Subject position	Accountability outcome
Airbnb (platform)	100,000 housed (01a-OC-002); 210,000 stays (01a-OC-003)	IOM partnership (01a-OC-005)	Platform exacerbates housing crisis (01a-MC-001); West Bank donations (01a-CS-002)	Service user; must create account, verify identity, accept commercial terms (01a-OC-006)	No change to platform model
Mastercard (financial)	"Life-saving assistance at the last mile" (Miebach, 2023); Peace Honors (02a-OC-004)	White House (02a-OC-003); WFP (02a-OC-005); UN Security Council	"Seeding the market" (02a-OC-002); "surveillance humanitarianism" (02a-CS-001)	Economic subject; cards blocked two months, no appeals (02a-MC-004)	No change to commercial infrastructure
Palantir-WFP (data/AI)	"Transform global humanitarian delivery" (04a-OC-001); 100M beneficiaries/year (04a-OC-004)	WFP partnership	65 CSOs: "accountability vacuum" (04a-CS-001); ICE abuses (04a-CS-003)	Data subject; algorithmic classification; no inspection or challenge	Partnership extended (04a-MC-005)
Starlink (connectivity)	"Starlink service is now active in Ukraine" (03a-OC-001); 150,000 daily users	None (unilateral)	"Privatized diplomacy" (03a-CS-003); volatility of CEO commitment	Connectivity dependent; same authority activated and deactivated infrastructure	Pentagon funding demanded; position reversed by tweet
Tesla (energy)	Powerwall deployment, Puerto Rico	None documented	"Solar graveyard" (05a-MC-001)	Energy-dependent community	Weakest evidence; single case

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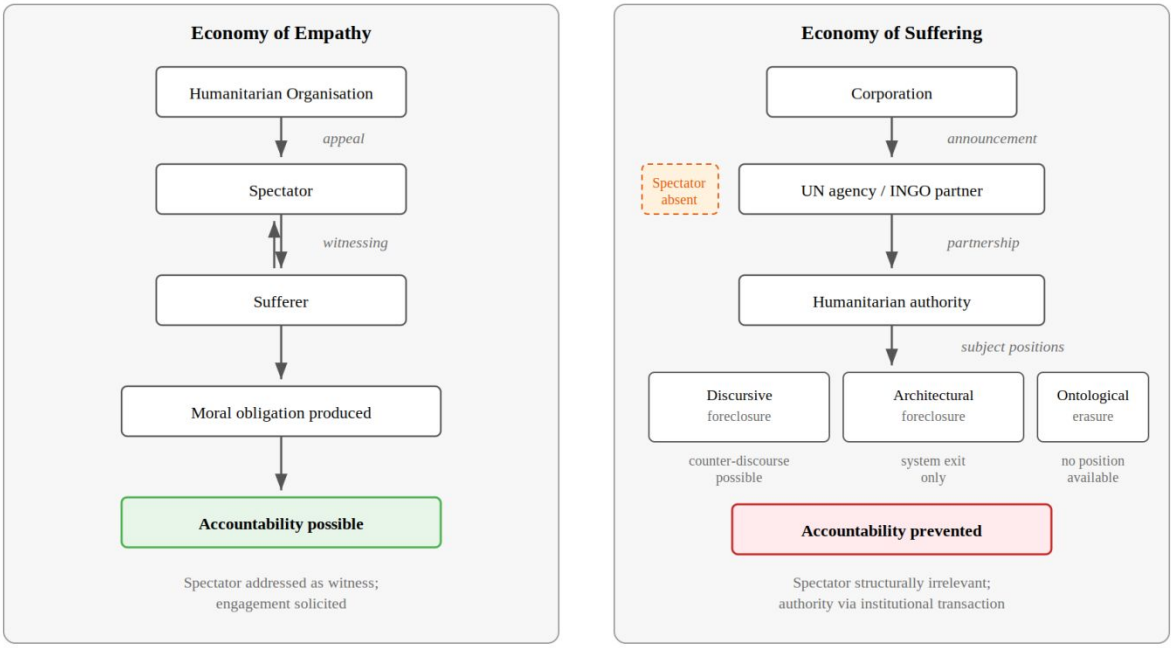
Figure 1

From the Economy of Empathy to the Economy of Suffering

Figure 1. From the Economy of Empathy to the Economy of Suffering



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